

The framework aims at addressing: (i) the recognition of the research profession and PhD qualifications within and outside academia, the structuring of the researcher scientific career (i.e. to improve interoperability between academia and other employers), (ii) the diversification of the careers of talents trained as researcher, (iii) solutions to the precariousness of researchers' careers in academia including a model tenure-track system accompanied by possible standard principles, and (iv) strengthened interaction with business to facilitate access to the labour market.

The common framework for research careers is expected to be based on dynamic competence profiles of researchers in various stages of their diverse careers in order to enable widespread recognition of the competences that PhD trainees and postdocs have obtained, both within and outside academia independent of sector or discipline and geographical location. It should be translated in the new European competence framework⁹¹, which will need to be mainstreamed across Europe.

We expect projects to take measures to improve flow-through of talent within academia and to and from the non-academic sector or to other highly needed positions in academia, to (i) improve transferable skills training, involving non-academic actors in education and training of researchers from the onset, (ii) improve talent transfer to actors in the surrounding ecosystem, (iii) improve value creation practices among higher education institutions, (iv) communicate about the competences and qualifications of researchers and their talents to economic actors and society as a whole, (v) initiatives enabling the sustainable and dynamic interaction within and between the ecosystem actors for knowledge production, circulation and use, and stimulating career fluidity through inter-institutional and inter-sectoral mobility (bi-directionally), (vi) embed additional elements in the assessment schemes for both organisations and individuals at all career stages, (vii) propose methodologies on how to introduce skills requirements from the business, social and public sector to academia.

Activities should include the establishment of pilot (for instance) local talent management centres and training hubs that strengthen involvement of the non-academic sector in defining the priorities of researchers' training and lifelong learning upskilling. Attention should be paid to addressing gender equality related issues throughout the different strands of the proposed framework.

Duration: The action should be no longer than 2 years.

HORIZON-WIDERA-2022-ERA-01-51: Acceleration Services in support of the institutional transformation of Higher Education Institutions

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of between EUR 2.50 and 3.50 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and

⁹¹ COM(2020)628, Commission Communication, A new ERA for Research and Innovation

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	selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 10.50 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following outcomes in relation to acceleration services in support of the institutional transformation of higher education institutions (HEI):

- A methodology towards acceleration services that can help HEI or alliances/networks of HEIs in pursuing institutional transformations, including a monitoring mechanism to assess quality of the delivered services.
- A coaching service with best practice examples and guidance for individual HEIs as well as networks of HEIs, aligned with the common transformation agenda, facilitating access to finance from various sources.
- Tested acceleration services with user groups (HEI umbrella organisations, individual HEIs, or networks of HEIs, including partners from surrounding ecosystems), supporting HEI or networks of HEIs in developing a strategy to pursue institutional transformations in the field of R&I.
- An investment strategy mechanism, implemented with the user group, facilitating access to funding from national, regional, or EU resources to deliver on the Higher Education Transformation Agenda.
- Progress of the user groups of the acceleration services regarding the implementation of the chosen areas of the transformation agenda, measured through a monitoring mechanism.
- Policy feedback to the European Commission and Member States on the acceleration services, and widespread dissemination of the pilot results to other target groups

Scope: The overall aim of the Higher Education Institutions acceleration services is to help institutions to successfully implement a strategy and roadmap for transformation, by creating a shared knowledge base, coaching service and virtual meeting place for them to connect with peers and other ecosystem actors, as well as with investors and public funders. The acceleration services should consist of (i) a coaching and support mechanism for HEIs to pursue institutional transformation in various areas, (ii) a methodology for an investment strategy to facilitate access of higher education institutions and surrounding ecosystem to support to deliver on the chosen transformations, (iii) a monitoring mechanism to assess progress in the transformation efforts. Projects should address all three aspects and test them with user groups.

HEIs, including universities, are crucial drivers of knowledge ecosystems, and increasingly also of innovation ecosystems. The new ERA is expected to strengthen the R&I dimension of

HEIs through a comprehensive institutional Higher Education Transformation Agenda in synergy with the European Education Area, reinforcing their role as drivers of change, fostering their recovery, enabling shared objectives between the EU and Member States' initiatives to support higher education institutions in their efforts to transform on their education, research, innovation and service to society missions. To deliver on the transformation agenda for HEIs a large-scale concerted action in support of the institutional transformation efforts of HEIs will be required, including a standard methodology to develop roadmaps of EU, national and regional actions and investment measures for institutions or alliances.

Projects should build on the results of previous analyses that set out a framework for empowering HEIs across Europe in their research and innovation mission, facilitating ongoing transformation processes based on universities' needs (*"Towards a 2030 Vision on the Future of Universities in the field of research and innovation in Europe"*, October 2020⁹²), and the analyses performed under the previous Work Programme (in particular the study *"Knowledge ecosystems in the new ERA: a comprehensive analysis of the state of play, the design of monitoring mechanisms, and creation of a toolbox of support measures"*, 2021). The projects should link and build on the results of the initiative of the European Institute of Innovation and Technology (EIT) on Innovation Capacity Building for Higher Education launched in 2021 that has the objective to unlock the full innovation potential of higher education institutions (HEIs).

The Higher Education Transformation Agenda developed under the previous Work Programme is expected to include the most important priorities and challenges for HEIs regarding institutional transformations towards the future, including (trans)national cooperation with other HEIs, and the growing importance of engagement with a broad range of sectors and societal actors inherent to the multiple dimensions of HEI (education, research, innovation, service to society). Acceleration services should address all possible R&I areas of the Higher Education Transformation Agenda such as: (a) empower HEIs towards developing shared R&I strategies that deliver on Europe's challenges with critical mass; (b) facilitate the sharing of capacity, infrastructure and resources through collaborative settings, such as the European Universities initiative; (c) improve the attractiveness of researchers' careers, including through reform of the career assessment and incentives regimes; (d) facilitate co-operation with surrounding R&I ecosystem actors; (e) support the transition to knowledge- and digitally-driven HEIs that mainstream Open Science practices and include research and innovation outputs in teaching; (f) engage citizens in solving societal challenges; (g) support institutional change through inclusive gender equality plans.

Projects are expected to a methodology how to deploy such acceleration services including (i) access to coaches, mentors, expertise and training from academia or outside academia, with different profiles that match with the areas from the transformation agenda, which the project puts at the disposal of individual HEIs or networks of universities in need of institutional transformation in the field of R&I; these experts, coaches, mentors, etc should provide

⁹² <https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/a3cde934-12a0-11eb-9a54-01aa75ed71a1/language-en>